



Deadly duo: Leander Paes (right) and Mahesh Bhupathi celebrate after beating Brazil's Marcelo Melo and Bruno Soares during the Davis Cup World Group play-off in Chennai on September 18, 2010. R. RAGU

with tennis today? Where's the feeder system? In football, hockey, and javelin, where's the feeder system? In such a huge country, how many have access to world-class tennis facilities? I am not talking about the infrastructure needed to play sports; I am not talking about the maidans. I am talking about the systematic training academy or high-performance centres that would

pick talents at the age of 10 or 12 and tell that person that they will stick with them for the next 20 years and make them a champion.

You look at countries like England, Spain, and Holland and their approaches to football. Or look at Australia and how they excel in every Olympic sport — the reason they have won six cricket World Cups is because there's a tradition there. Sport is a big part of their education curriculum, but that's not the case here.

Do you think the AITA needs a fresh approach and restructure its domestic tournaments?

The infrastructure of sports has

developed a lot in our country. The synthetic turfs have been introduced, we have floodlights, and the gyms are being used a lot more. But I think it's one thing to go to the gym to become a professional athlete and a world champion, and it's completely different to play the sport at an amateur level. However, that differentiation is not being recognised. There's a huge difference between the two, and we need to understand that.

When you partnered with Bhupathi and focused on doubles, many in the fraternity believed it was a wrong move to shift away from singles, which earned you an Olympic medal. But three decades later, do you feel it was an emotional decision, or was it the correct choice?

My realisation as a young boy was to achieve an Olympic medal in an individual sport. Not many people understood it, let alone wanted to realise that achievement for themselves. Not many people were willing to put in those hard yards or go through the lifestyle it takes to compete at seven Olympics.

People didn't understand it, so obviously people misunderstood me. The purpose that I had was basically to rewrite history books. Ironically, we're having this conversation when I'm being inducted into the Hall of Fame.

I can't expect people to understand what my journey was. I felt it was better to lead by example than waste time explaining it. I lived my life the best I could, and when I decided to shift to doubles and mixed doubles after enjoying success in singles, it came with the belief that we could win Grand Slams. And today, sitting here having won two junior singles Grand Slams and 18 senior doubles Grand Slams is a satisfying feeling. I have been very blessed to have had a phenomenal career, and I dedicate it to my team, which has been with me through thick and thin. In times like these, where everyone is busy projecting an image, on social media or in public, I just let my racquet do the talking.